during this period included India's nuclear tests in Pokhran followed closely by those of Pakistan, the Kargil war, natural disasters like the supercyclone in Orissa, the earthquake in Bhuj and an outstanding military action, Operation Khukri, undertaken by the Indian Army and Air Force as part of UN operations in Sierra Leone. In this action, we were able to secure the safe rescue and relief of two companies (233 peacekeepers) of our battalion, which had been encircled by rebels at Kailahun. In addition, we were able to free seventeen UN observers who had been made hostage by these rebels. What made this operation stand out was that all peacekeeping contingents except ours laid down their weapons in front of the rebels. I recall that the UK government made a request that Major Andy Harrison, one of the UN observers from the British Army, be rescued on priority. We replied that the lives of all peacekeepers were equally precious and that efforts would be made to ensure their safe evacuation. Therefore we gave the go-ahead for Operation Khukri. I accompanied the defence minister to Sierra Leone to congratulate the Indian forces for their resounding success.

I met Brigadier Rajpal Punia in 2011, and he told me the story of their siege for about three months without any lifeline and with limited rations. He was a major at that time and was a part of the isolated position in Kailahun. A breakout with the support of attack helicopters was executed by the beleaguered sub units and link up established with the rescuing force. Thereafter, we flew out all the observers, including Major Harrison. This operation is spoken of as a 'great success' in case studies of UN peacekeeping, according to Brigadier Punia.

As part of our ongoing negotiations on the boundary dispute with China, I visited Beijing in the latter half of 1998 as a member of our joint working group comprising the representatives of the ministries of defence, external, home affairs, and the army. Our deliberations lasted for a day-and-a-half. Expectedly, nothing much came out of our discussions with the Chinese. We reiterated our position that we should exchange maps giving our respective alignment of the line of actual control (LAC), and commence the reconciliation from the area where we have the least variation. That is, from the central